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# The Pre-Bed Wind-Down Se- quence

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10 minutes that physically shift your body into  
sleep-ready mode

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

## **The Pre-Bed Wind-Down Sequence**

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# Introduction

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A BETWEEN SESSIONS BONUS — TEN MINUTES of body-based wind-down that works better than melatonin.

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If you're lying in bed scrolling your phone and wondering why you can't sleep — this is your replacement. Ten minutes. It works better than melatonin.

I get asked about sleep constantly. Clients tell me they can't fall asleep, can't stay asleep, wake up tired. They've tried magnesium, melatonin, sleep stories, blackout curtains, white noise machines. Some of those help. Most are working downstream of the actual problem.

The actual problem is usually this: their body never got the signal that it's time to sleep. Their nervous system is still in "doing" mode when they hit the pillow. Then they wonder why they can't shut off.

Sleep isn't something you decide to do. It's something your body does when conditions are right. The job of the pre-bed routine is to create those conditions — physically, in the body — before you ever lie down.

This sequence does that.

## CHAPTER 1

# Why body-based, not mind-based

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**MOST PRE-BED ROUTINES ARE MIND-BASED:** meditation apps, sleep stories, gratitude journaling. They can help, but they're treating the wrong layer.

When you can't sleep, your body is usually in an elevated nervous-system state. Heart rate slightly up. Breathing shallow. Muscles holding tension. The brain trying to talk the body into relaxing while the body is still in low-grade arousal is like trying to convince yourself you're not hungry when you haven't eaten in a day.

You have to actually shift the body's physiology first. Once the body downshifts, the mind follows automatically. Reverse the order and you're fighting biology.

This sequence works because every move in it is specifically chosen to physically activate the parasympathetic nervous system — your body's "rest and digest" mode.



## CHAPTER 2

# The 10-minute sequence

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**FIVE MOVES. TWO MINUTES EACH. DO THEM IN this order. Don't skip ahead.**

You can do this on the floor next to your bed, on the bed itself if it's firm enough, or in a quiet spot in your bedroom. Lights low. No phone. No TV.

### Move 1 — Legs up the wall (2 minutes)

This is the most important move. If you only have time for one, do this one.

**Setup:** Sit sideways against a wall, hip touching the baseboard. Lie down on your back as you swing your legs up the wall. Adjust until your butt is as close to the wall as comfortable.

Your legs are now straight up against the wall. Arms relax at your sides, palms up or on your belly. Eyes closed.

**Just stay there.** Breathe normally. Let your back release into the floor. Let your shoulders drop. Let your jaw soften.

The inverted leg position does several things:

- Drains pooled blood from your legs back toward the heart, which gently activates the parasympathetic response
- Decompresses the low back
- Signals your nervous system through a posture it associates with deep rest

Two minutes. That's all. Don't rush it.

## Move 2 — Spinal twist on your back (1 minute each side)

Still on your back. Bring your knees toward your chest, then let them fall to the right side. Arms out to the sides in a T shape. Turn your head to look left.

Stay for one minute. Breathe slow and deep into your back.

Switch sides — knees to the left, head to the right. One minute.

This decompresses the spine after the leg-up position and continues the nervous-system downshift through gentle rotation.

## Move 3 — Diaphragmatic breathing (2 minutes)

Lie flat on your back. Place one hand on your chest, one on your belly.

Breathe slowly so that ONLY the belly hand moves. Chest stays still.

**Pattern:** Inhale through your nose for 4 counts. Exhale through your mouth for 6 counts.

The longer exhale is the key. The exhale phase of breath is the primary activator of the parasympathetic nervous system. Slowing down your exhale specifically tells your body “we’re safe, we can rest.”

Do this for two full minutes. Just breath. Belly moving, chest still.

You may notice your jaw start to drop on its own. Your shoulders settle further. Your face soften. Those are signs the parasympathetic system is engaging.

## Move 4 — Progressive muscle relaxation (3 minutes)

Stay lying on your back. Eyes closed.

You’re going to tighten and release every muscle group in your body, one at a time. Each one: tighten as hard as you can for 5 seconds, then release completely for 10 seconds. Notice the difference between tense and relaxed at each station.

Order:

- 1. Feet** — curl your toes hard, scrunch your feet. Hold 5. Release.
- 2. Calves** — flex your feet upward, contract your calves. Hold 5. Release.

- 3. Thighs** — tighten your quadriceps. Hold 5. Release.
- 4. Glutes** — squeeze your butt muscles. Hold 5. Release.
- 5. Stomach** — tighten your abs as if bracing for a punch. Hold 5. Release.
- 6. Hands** — make tight fists. Hold 5. Release.
- 7. Arms** — flex biceps and triceps. Hold 5. Release.
- 8. Shoulders** — pull shoulders up toward ears. Hold 5. Release.
- 9. Face** — scrunch your whole face. Hold 5. Release.

By the time you finish the face, your body has been through a full physical “stand down” pattern. Everything is heavier, looser, warmer.

## Move 5 — Stillness in stillness (2 minutes)

Lie still. Don’t move. Don’t do anything. Just stay where you are with your eyes closed.

Notice the heaviness of your body against the bed/floor. Notice your breath has slowed. Notice your mind has quieted (or, if it hasn’t, notice that without judging it — just observe).

Don’t try to fall asleep here. Don’t try to do anything. Just hold the position you’re in for two minutes.

When you're done, get into bed slowly. Move smoothly, not abruptly. Maintain the calm state you just created all the way into sleep position.

## CHAPTER 3

# What to expect

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FIRST TIME YOU DO THIS, YOU MAY NOT FEEL dramatically different. The nervous system takes a few exposures to recognize a new pattern as a “sleep signal.”

By day 4-5 of doing it nightly, most people start noticing:

- Falling asleep within 10-15 minutes of getting into bed
- Less mind-racing once horizontal
- Deeper sleep through the first half of the night
- Waking up feeling slightly more rested

By day 14, the sequence becomes a sleep cue. Just starting it begins the relaxation response, even before you’ve finished.

## CHAPTER 4

# When to do it (and when not to)

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**BEST TIMING:** 15-30 MINUTES BEFORE YOU ACTUALLY want to be asleep. Not in bed — the sequence is a transition INTO bed, not something you do once you're under the covers.

### **Don't do it when:**

- You're already in bed exhausted and falling asleep — just go to sleep
- You're traveling and don't have privacy — substitute breathing-only version (3-5 min of diaphragmatic breathing)
- You're with a partner who needs lights on or the room engaged — adapt to whatever space you have

### **Adapt as needed:**

- Tight on time? Shorten each move by half. 5-minute version still works.
- Older or less mobile? Skip the legs-up-the-wall if it's uncomfortable getting into. Substitute legs on a chair or couch with your back flat on the floor — knees bent at 90 degrees, legs supported.

## CHAPTER 5

# The phone problem

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IF YOU DO THIS SEQUENCE AND THEN IMMEDIATELY pick up your phone, you've just undone the entire thing.

Bright screens activate the visual cortex and signal “daytime” to the nervous system you just spent 10 minutes downshifting. The light wavelengths from screens also suppress melatonin production.

This sequence works only if you commit to NOT picking up your phone after. Read a paper book. Get into bed. Sleep. Anything that maintains the low-light, low-stimulation state.

If you can't put the phone down, the sequence is wasted effort. Be honest about which problem you're actually trying to solve.



## CHAPTER 6

# Closing

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REPLACE 10 MINUTES OF SCREEN TIME WITH this. One week. See what happens to your sleep.

Most sleep problems aren't sleep problems — they're nervous-system problems showing up at bedtime. This sequence addresses the nervous system directly. The sleep follows.

Ten minutes. Tonight. Don't overthink it.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,  
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